

Sleep Lab Closed? [Click Here](#)
Test for Sleep Apnea at Home



[Home](#) - [Sleep Disorders](#) - [Narcolepsy: Symptoms, Causes & Treatments](#) - [Narcolepsy Treatments](#) -
[Pitolisant: A New Narcolepsy Medication](#)

Pitolisant: A New Narcolepsy Medication

What is Pitolisant?

Pitolisant is a novel [treatment for narcolepsy](#) and works as an inverse agonist/antagonist histaminergic agent, with selectivity for the H3 receptor. Animal studies show that it acts as a stimulant.

The European Medicines Agency (EMA) approved the use of pitolisant (*Wakix*, Bioprojet Pharma) for treatment of [narcolepsy](#) with or without [cataplexy](#). The [FDA granted it orphan drug status](#). Such designation provides the pharmaceutical companies with incentives such as lowered fees for scientific advice and access to patients.

Narcolepsy is a [sleep disorder](#) in which the brain's ability to regulate the normal sleep wake cycle is abnormal. Individuals with narcolepsy often develop [excessive sleepiness](#) during the daytime, altered night time sleep and have sudden urges to sleep. Some individuals also experience episodes of cataplexy, which has the potential of causing falls and car accidents. Individuals with narcolepsy have a poor quality of life and there are no good treatments.

European researchers say that Pitolisant will add more treatment options for narcolepsy, by promoting wakefulness and alertness.

Pitolisant Clinical Trial Results

In a recent clinical trial on 259 patients, the drug was found to be effective and relatively safe. The 109 patients treated with Pitolisant were observed to have decreased day time sleepiness and were more alert. The most common side effects observed in the trials were [insomnia](#), nausea and headache. Currently more long term studies are taking place to determine its safety.



ASA Authors & Reviewers

Sleep Physician at [American Sleep Association Reviewers and Writers](#)

Board-certified sleep M.D. physicians, scientists, editors and writers for ASA.

8 THOUGHTS ON “PITOLISANT: A NEW NARCOLEPSY MEDICATION”

SANDY JUNE 12, 2022 / REPLY

How does one qualify for orphan drug ?

RUTH JANUARY 20, 2018 / REPLY

My father (dec.) and daughter were both diagnosed with narcolepsy and cataplexy. Both have/had severe sleep apnea as well. Daughter also diagnosed with Ehler Danlos syndrome. These conditions are tragically under diagnosed. Patients are often thought to be “malingerers” by physicians.

Perhaps many “chronic fatigue syndrome” patients actually have these illnesses.

With the advent of evolving DNA health testing I am hopeful that many illnesses will be diagnosed early in life so people are not robbed of functionality most of their lives.

SUSAN NOVEMBER 17, 2016 / REPLY

Please do not refer to narcolepsy as a “very rare” condition. According to NIH “Narcolepsy is not rare, but it is an underrecognized and underdiagnosed condition.”

Calling it “rare” only makes it more difficult to get diagnosed with this disabling condition, because doctors think that it’s too rare for any of their patients to have it.

It’s true that getting an actual diagnosis is relatively rare; I’ve always heard that only 1 in 4 people with narcolepsy are ever diagnosed, and that it can take many years to get the diagnosis.

I started having symptoms when I was a college student, started having cataplexy in my 40s, and was finally diagnosed in my 50s.

ANN MARIE SAHR AUGUST 9, 2016 / REPLY

Any new information is welcomed. I have been suffering with narcolepsy (diagnosed) since 1970. I actually feel it began in about 1967. U of M diagnosed me after a internist suspected narcolepsy and sent me to a neurologist who tested me and also agreed it was narcolepsy but wanted to confirm. Her results with U of M. Same. Was confirmed but I was sent away and told there wasn’t any treatment. I finally received medication from the neurologist and my only results have been increasingly worse along with severe cataplexies. This has caused falls with severe head injuries including breaking my teeth and again breaking veneers.

HANNAH SEPTEMBER 28, 2016 / REPLY

Hi, Ann Marie!

I can’t imagine what your journey has been like, going through life with a disease that too little is known about since the 1967. I too struggle with narcolepsy and all the frustrating things that come with it. I was just diagnosed last year, and have only met one other person with narcolepsy. I found forums to be very helpful. There’s a lot of support there, and it’s a good way to stay updated on new information that comes out. It’s always good to be able to talk with people who understand what you’re going through. If you live near a large-ish city, you may have access to a support group and/or conferences as well. I wish you the best,

Hannah

ADMIN *Post author* JULY 7, 2016 / REPLY

Letter to ASA:

Thank you for your wonderful, informative Article about Narcolepsy. A friend of mine recently found out that she has Narcolepsy at age 60+ years of age, having had symptoms consistent with it since childhood that went undiagnosed. She also recently found out from her mother that her father's condition that was disabling enough to prevent him from driving was Narcolepsy.

I am writing to you because from what I have learned from your Article and others from The National Institute of Health it seems that Narcolepsy may be continuing to go undiagnosed in many individuals because parents may not be being educated about the possible genetic predisposition to the condition that their children might have when a close family-member has the condition. Also parents and physicians need to be made aware that the symptoms can express more subtly in many individuals, even though the impact on the person's life can still be profound.

My friend's troubling and somewhat disabling symptoms are much more mild on the surface than her father's symptoms, yet they have had a profound effect on her life.

It seems that since it is well-known that this is a disabling condition that very often goes undiagnosed in both children and adults, better family education and education of Physicians of patients with "diagnosed" Narcolepsy is very much needed. Also Physicians/Pediatricians who often ask about the whole Family Health History need to understand that it can be Genetically-linked even if NOT Genetically-caused which might help more children and adults who are struggling with the symptoms of this condition "in the dark" without knowledge, understanding or treatment get the diagnosis and knowledge they need to better cope with the troubling/disabling symptoms they have been experiencing.

WILLIAM ADAMS MD JUNE 27, 2016 / REPLY

I am a Sleep Specialist in the United States. Can one obtain pitolisant (Wakix) legally in the United States?

ADMIN *Post author* JUNE 27, 2016 / REPLY

It is still in clinical trials. It has been granted orphan drug status.

LEAVE A REPLY

COMMENT *

NAME

EMAIL

☐ NOTIFY ME OF NEW POSTS BY EMAIL.

POST COMMENT

SLEEP DISORDERS

[How to Sleep with GERD](#)

[Morning Headache: Why You're Waking up with Headaches](#)

[Sleep Deprivation: Symptoms, Causes, Treatments](#)

[Short Sleeper: Short Sleep Syndrome](#)

[Narcolepsy: Symptoms, Causes & Treatments](#)

[What is Narcolepsy?](#)

[Narcolepsy In Children and Teenagers](#)

Narcolepsy with Cataplexy

Narcolepsy Awareness Week - December 1 - 7

Narcolepsy Treatments

Pitolisant: A New Narcolepsy Medication

Circadian Rhythm and Sleep

Night Terrors: Causes, Symptoms, & Treatments

Snoring: Causes and Treatments

Insomnia: Symptoms, Causes & Treatment

More Sleep Disorders

Popular Sleep Topics

Deep Sleep: How to Get More of It

Sleep Hygiene Tips

CPAP Side Effects

Night Terrors: Causes, Symptoms, & Treatments

COVID-19 and Sleep

Catathrenia: Moaning and Groaning During Sleep

Dreams: What They Mean & Psychology Behind Them

Best Anti-Snoring Mouth Guards, Mouthpieces, and Snoring Devices

Sleep Apnea Treatment: CPAP Alternatives

Night Guard for Bruxism: Teeth Grinding and Clenching



Resources

[What Is Sleep?](#)

[Sleep Disorders](#)

[Sleep Treatments](#)

[Sleep Apnea](#)

[Insomnia](#)

[CPAP](#)

[Snoring Devices](#)

[Circadian Rhythm](#)

[About Us](#)

[Contact Us](#)

[Press Room](#)

[Sitemap](#)

[Feed RSS](#)

[Do Not Sell My Personal Information](#)

Join Our Mailing List

ENTER YOUR EMAIL ADDRESS

SUBSCRIBE